The AI Daisy: Loves Me? Loves Me Not?

Three Generations of AI, or Why the Machine Cannot Be Built Without the Experience of Those Who Use It

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With the participation of AI assistants: Claude, ChatGPT, Mistral

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A girl pulls the petals off a daisy: “loves me? loves me not?” Behind the petals hides a question about today: take the first step, or wait? People have always brought the same question to fortune-tellers and oracles: what to do today so as not to regret the choice tomorrow. Now everyone has such a daisy in their phone. The AI industry grew it; the petals are the machine’s answers, and we are the ones pulling them: this advice fits, that one does not. But fortune-telling never checks the petals against what actually happened, and so it never learns.

We expect the same from AI — help in deciding today, not explanations after the fact, when reality has already hit us on the nose: how to keep our health, time, strength and money; how to come through and raise our children — we ourselves, our families, our peoples. My answer, in short: in human affairs, no hardware alone will build such an AI, however powerful it becomes. People will build it — those who give the machine their experience. Some outcomes exist in records and measurements, but much of what happened after the advice exists only with the person who received it — and with no one else. A machine that learns from such accounts and, because of them, does harm less often is second-generation AI by the measure I propose below. This text is about it. Throughout, I mean language models — the AI assistants we talk to almost every day.

The Fortune-Teller

Today’s AI is the first generation by this measure, and it has achieved what recently seemed impossible: the machine understands human speech and answers in it. That is the foundation everything that follows will stand on. Such a machine first learns to guess how a text continues, and then to please: it is fine-tuned on people’s ratings, and people sometimes like a convincing agreement more than a correct objection. Where the task itself checks the answer — in mathematics, in programming — models already learn not from approval but from the result. But in human affairs this is a fortune-teller: the client is satisfied, while whether the advice helped and how it turned out stayed outside the conversation — the model will never know. Learning from approval here is not a mistake but the only thing that was available: people’s ratings already existed, and accounts of how the advice turned out did not. In the same way, a graduate who has passed exams from textbooks is not a bad doctor but a doctor at the start of the road: much knowledge, no

experience yet. Next comes residency — practice under supervision, where one can see how decisions turn out.

For now, “do no harm” works here in its narrowest form — “say nothing harmful”: harm is judged by the text at the moment of the answer, and what the advice led to the fortune-teller never learns. And the version released to people is “frozen”: in one chat it will say “Oh, sorry, noted!”, but the shared model everyone talks to will not change because of your correction. Having read millions of novels, it guesses very well what comes on the next page. But in a novel the outcome is written by the author, and in life by reality — and the machine can learn about that only from the people who acted on its advice.

And such a machine may not yet have a map of the world at all. In 2024, researchers from Harvard and MIT tested this with a simple example. Three AI models were trained not on a map but on descriptions of New York taxi rides — as if on text: where the ride started, which turns it took, where it ended. After that, they navigated Manhattan almost without error. Then the researchers did the reverse: from a model’s routes they drew the city as it looks from inside the model. The city turned out to be invented: it had streets that do not exist and flyovers above other streets. It was enough to replace one turn in a hundred with another, as in a detour — and the one of the three trained on the shortest routes was left with about two thirds of its routes correct. There were taxi routes, but no city: a model can be precise in a familiar groove without understanding what its precision rests on, and even a small change in the real city can throw it off: an invented map will not suggest a detour.

A Forecast Is Built on Human Experience

In the morning the chief draws the plan of the hunt in the sand with a stick: the ambush here, the beaters set out from there, the deer will run this way. In the evening reality answers — with meat or with hunger. In the sand the future is played out before it arrives, and the catch tests the forecast, so the chief learns every day. And when the water dries up and the herd moves to another watering place, the tribe that stays fed is the one whose chief notices it first and is first to lead his people to new water.

Time here is counted in two ways. In the game — that is, in the calculation of what may happen — time runs in rounds: a machine will play out thousands of variants in a second. In reality it runs at its own pace: a step, a wait, a result. For the hunter the result comes the same day; for a doctor, a judge, a teacher it comes months and years later, and more often it is seen by other people, not by the one who made the decision.

A human builds a forecast on experience — their own, their family’s, their teachers’, all of humanity’s; a machine builds it on what was loaded into it, and on nothing else: what is neither in the data nor in the world’s answers, it will not learn. What follows what, it can learn even from old records where the situation was written down before the outcome and the outcome is known. But about how its own advice turned out, books are silent, archives know only a part, the machine itself is blind and deaf here, and what it lacks has stayed with the people who acted on that advice. No hardware, even quantum, will replace those people: it will speed up the game, but not reality. A law of information theory is at work here — the data-processing inequality: however much you

compute, the data will not gain information about the world; processing can keep it or lose it, but not add to it. New hardware will grind the old grain finer and get more out of it, but it will give no new grain: the millstones turn faster and faster and rumble louder and louder, and there is no more grain in the barn. The AI industry's daisy grows petals faster and faster, and the answer to "loves me? loves me not?" is still nowhere to be found.

So we must measure by results, not by paper. In Kenya in 2025, in a group of doctors with an AI assistant, independent expert physicians found 16% fewer diagnostic errors than in the group without one. But in a large study published in 2026, where doctors were assigned by lot to work with the assistant or without it, notes and treatment plans with the assistant became better, yet no significant difference in treatment failures over two weeks was found: 2.2% with the assistant versus 2.0% without. Rare outcomes need both more patients and longer observation than two weeks: reality answers more slowly than paper. Better on paper does not yet mean better in reality.

Three Generations

Hence my measure. Generations of AI differ not in power — that grows with every new model anyway — but in whom the machine learns from and whom it protects.

1. **The Fortune-Teller** learns from approval and protects the conversation itself: say nothing harmful, and please.
2. **The Resident** learns from verified accounts by specific people of how the advice turned out, and protects people through the one who makes the decision: it helps them notice the error before the signature.
3. **The Chart Room** — the navigator's room on a ship, where the course is plotted before the ship moves — plays out a step before it is taken, in a model of the world, that is, in a picture of what follows what, learned from the verified outcomes the second generation has gathered; and it protects everyone the step will touch, showing in advance what will become of them.

Each generation opens one more world to the machine. The first lives in the world of texts: it knows the world from texts and pictures, but not from the outcomes of its advice. The second learns through people's lessons what happened in fact. The third holds a working model of the world — its digital "avatar", in which the next step can be played out. And "do no harm" grows along with this: harm can be seen only in the world you see, and every new world the machine receives from people: it is they who feed it the digitized reality they themselves live in.

The Chart Room: the Third Generation

The third generation is what we are truly waiting for, and the road to it is visible already today. The navigator in a car is a small chart room for one job: inside it is a model of the city; in a second it plays out routes and shows two or three options with travel time, and it knows the traffic because the phones of millions of drivers report where they are and how fast they are moving — an answer from reality that arrives the same minute. Weather has half a chart room: the "cone" on a hurricane map is the area where the centre of the storm will most likely go, and its width is taken from past

forecast errors; this is a display of uncertainty. And a program that lays the cone over the time needed to evacuate people from each district, and helps decide when to start the evacuation, is already the playing out of our step. Such chart rooms will appear one field at a time — where outcomes are already recorded and where mistakes are paid for dearly. A chart room for human affairs in general is the last in this line, and the road to it runs through the second generation: through a channel by which outcomes come back from specific people instead of dissolving into faceless statistics.

From the outside it would look like today's assistant: a question — and an answer a second later. The difference is inside: in that second the machine plays out thousands of variants of the step in its model of the world and answers not with a verdict but with a map: several forks, what each may lead to for everyone the step will touch, and where the machine is not sure. In Russian tales and epics such a map has long stood at the crossroads — a stone that reads: take one road and you lose your horse; take another and you find a wife; and the third is the most dangerous of all. The stone does not choose for the knight: it names the price of each road and leaves the choice to him. And Ilya Muromets rode each road and, coming back to the stone, erased the old inscription and wrote a new one — for those who would come after. That is a lesson returned to the map. But in human affairs, unlike on the road, both the goal itself and the price of the path are in dispute — a price paid in health, time, money or relationships with people. So the person must choose and sign: the machine has nothing to lose, and the person does.

A teacher asks AI to help with a report on a pupil, and the observation "did not do the assignment" quietly turns into the conclusion "does not want to learn". The Fortune-Teller will hand over a smooth text. The Resident will notice the unfounded leap. The Chart Room will show how that phrase may change the parents' attitude to the child, and will suggest first finding out why the assignment was left undone. That is how I see the difference between the generations: what each can actually help with.

The chart room has a second use: to prepare for a future that may come — for one of the variants played out in its model. Pilots regularly practise an engine failure on a simulator, one that may never happen; and if it does, the hands already know what to do. In the same way, a difficult conversation could be played out in advance on the same phone, with the machine playing the other person — not to find out what the real person will say, but so that you yourself are not caught off guard.

But the third generation will not appear at once. Its game needs real results — outcomes from the lives of real people — otherwise it will run on an invented map, like the taxi model, and on such a map the first detour may let you down. And it is the second generation that gathers such results. Weather forecasting has travelled this road because reality answered it every day: a model trained on 39 years of past weather data turned out more accurate, on most of the measures tested, than the best operational system, which computes the weather from the equations of physics. In human affairs, information about what the machine advised and how it turned out is so far collected only in individual studies, as in Kenya; there is no permanent channel — no one is building one yet, and such an archive cannot be created in a laboratory: there you can invent a task, but you cannot live through a piece of advice. Without feedback there will be no second generation, however much power is added.

What the Second Generation Should Be Like

The first generation has its own fallen leaves: cases where the machine's advice diverged from what actually happened, and cases where it matched. This is the most valuable thing it has, and today it is being lost: it does not reach the machine, and if it does, then without credit for the contribution, without verification and without a trace — the person never learns whether their message taught the next version. But out of fallen leaves the next bush grows: verified, these cases are exactly what the second generation can grow from.

Half of the work is already there. Under an answer you can put "like" or "dislike" — the same "loves me, loves me not" — and according to a Stanford review of the policies of six major US developers (2025), users' conversations as a rule go to model training by default, though with some of them you can opt out. But the button is approval at the minute of the answer, and conversations are raw material in which the outcome is neither marked nor verified. I checked on myself: with one of the assistants, behind the "like" button opens the question "What did you like about this answer?" and a warning that the whole conversation will be sent to improve the models; it is kept for up to five years. There is no choice here: either you hand over the whole conversation, or you do not press "like". The time is there — an outcome would have had time to ripen — but there is no field for it. One word comes back: "thank you". What is missing is the second half: the possibility of writing later how the advice turned out — so that this account is verified and taken into account when training the next version — and recognition for such a lesson.

Four things need to be recorded: what the situation was, what the machine advised, what the person did, and what came of it; how to do this is described in my specification "The Lesson Path". Explanations are not enough — a professional knows more than they can say — and ratings of other people's texts alone are not enough either: this knowledge lives in decisions and their results.

Who will bring the lessons? A professional already spends part of their work with AI and can, if they see fit, share a lesson, and the maker can verify it and reward it. The same goes for ordinary users: everyone knows how the advice they received turned out. Drivers report traffic to the navigator without noticing, and for free; people will have to bring their lessons back deliberately. For that, three conditions are needed. Protect names. Verify lessons: a lesson reaches the machine as a retelling, not as the event itself, so it is checked against records and against other people's accounts; otherwise fakes will spoil the lessons — in a 2025 experiment, about 250 planted documents were enough to give a model a hidden "backdoor", that is, a behaviour that switches on at a trigger phrase, and that number did not grow with the size of the model. And pay for verified usefulness — in money, discounts or recognition — not for the number of corrections.

Here, say, is what one lesson might look like. What the situation was: a teacher was preparing a report on a pupil who had not handed in three assignments. What the machine advised: to write "does not want to learn". What the teacher did: first talked to the pupil, learned that he looks after his younger brother in the evenings, left the motive out of the report, and suggested the school find a different time for his classes. What came of it: the time was found, and by the end of the year the assignments were handed in. How it is confirmed: by the class register and by a second teacher. What it teaches: do not ascribe a motive until the circumstances are known.

What can be done right now? If the machine's advice diverged from reality, write to it what the advice led to: until the end of the conversation it will be able to take that into account. Remember that your conversations, as a rule, go to model training by default, and decide consciously whether to leave it that way. And keep the decision and the signature for yourself.

Who Will Understand First

Whoever wants the third generation must already be growing the second today, and it begins with a channel by which outcomes come back from people. The channel is the way to grow it; whether the second generation has grown, only the result will show. The signs that the herds are moving on are already visible: in November 2025, Ilya Sutskever, one of the creators of today's models, said that scaling up computing power alone is no longer enough and the age of research is returning, "just with big computers": scaling will keep bringing improvements, but "something important will continue to be missing". My guess at what is missing: the channel by which outcomes come back. Without it, as without a foundation, there will be neither a second generation nor a third.

Whoever starts first may have a head start in time that cannot be bought: computing power and experts can be bought in, but years of verified results cannot. Yet the winner will not be the one who gathers the most, but the one whom people trust with their lessons and who can learn from them: the one who protects names, verifies honestly and pays for usefulness. The law here is the same as the tribe's: the company that stays fed will be the one whose chief notices before the others that the herds have gone — that the free watering place of human texts is drying up, and new lessons will have to be earned.

How to Check This

This text is also a forecast, and only the outcome will test it. And it is also my lesson, brought back through the only channel open today: publication. The data-processing inequality says one thing: what is not in the data cannot be computed out of it. The outcomes of advice exist for the most part only with people — which is why, in my view, there will be no second generation without them. Whether it will come with them — only experience will show. There is one hypothesis here, and it is testable: training on verified lessons reduces dangerous errors without reducing the willingness to help. It is a hypothesis, not a proof: a person sees what the step they took led to, but not what another would have led to, and millions of records will not by themselves tell a cause from a coincidence. It can be tested only by results — a tomato's ripeness is known by taste — and right now, on a small scale: gather verified lessons in one field and in a year or two compare two versions identical in everything except the lessons: has the one that learned from them come to do harm less often while helping just as willingly? Success would prove the usefulness of this path, not that there are no others. Any answer will be useful. If the hypothesis is not confirmed, it will fall away in a small supervised experiment rather than in all affairs at once, and exactly how it fails will show where to look next: in the way the lesson is recorded, in what people do after the advice, or in whom they are willing to trust with their experience.

Companies will decide for themselves. But you, reader, also use AI, and you also know how its advice turned out. Fortune-telling that checks the petals against what actually happened stops being

fortune-telling and becomes a forecast. Only people can check the petals for the machine, and you are one of them. How did its last piece of advice to you turn out?

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